

Editorial

Dear Readers,

Will Ubuntu become history now?

That's the question that popped in my mind when I read through the Google official blog on November 19—the day it open sourced its Chrome OS. Of course, the official title given to the open sourced version is Chromium OS—I guess Google has learnt a few things from Red Hat, when it comes to open sourcing projects.

The Chromium OS project includes the "... current code base, user interface experiments and some initial designs for ongoing development," according to Google. Why go open source now? To connect with the open source community and get it involved, obviously. What else did you expect?

To me, the Chrome OS can usher in a new era—one that (hopefully) will take Linux, open source and cloud computing to the masses. If this happens, many users, especially the new ones, may never recognise that shift, since this will then be the *de facto* way of life for them, just like Windows is today, for many.

Chrome will surely accelerate the demise of traditional client-server applications, and all that an application will need to interact with is the Web browser. Of course, all those who think that this will make life simpler for developers (as they won't have to worry about the underlying hardware)—think again. I have met many developers who took great pains to develop Web-based Taj Mahals, and then despaired when they realised that their creation looked dilapidated on other browsers.

So, how good is the Chrome OS? The answer will depend on whom you ask. Fans of Google will swear by it. While others simply consider it 'useless' right now. But then, the final version of this OS is expected only in the second half of next year (2010). So, if you can find flaws and report them, you would be helping the core team. It would be better still if you could contribute in developing some of the features on the 'to do' list.

Is Chrome an upgrade of the Android? No.

Android was designed from the beginning to work across a variety of devices—from phones and set-top boxes to netbooks. The Chrome OS is being designed to power computers ranging from small netbooks to full-sized desktops. While there are areas where the two overlap, they will be two separate open source projects powered by Google.

Back to our first question—what happens to Linux distros like Ubuntu that have gained popularity amongst end users? Will Chrome displace them? I hate to make wild predictions, but the gut feeling is that Google has most often got things right—whether it was with its search engine, with Google Docs or even Gmail. Plus, no one can refute the increased popularity of Web-based applications.

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Whatever be the outcome—two things are certain. Open source will emerge as a winner, and we will be there to report that.

Best Wishes!



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